

Condensation Structure of ENSO: Seasonal Memory, Topographic Anchoring, and Phase-Transition Geometry

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Predecessor: ENSO Simplified Prediction Note (10.5281/zenodo.21626908), ENSO Watch Dashboard (github.com/MMDR10/enso-watch)

Abstract

ENSO is traditionally understood as a large-scale ocean–atmosphere coupled oscillation, with mainstream methods (GCMs) achieving only ~50–60% accuracy at 6-month leads. This paper proposes a different measurement route: **instead of predicting the ENSO index, measure the spatial condensation structure of the equatorial Pacific SST density field** — the geometric folding of seasonal frontal systems, their positional memory, and the topographic anchoring of that memory.

Using 39 years of OISST 0.25° data (1982–2020), we find:

1. **p-field condensation is the norm ($D=1.334\pm0.016$, 60/60 months, $z=-46.4$):** the high-value cluster dimension of the SST seasonal activity density field (ρ) is far below random (null 1.73) — frontal systems **fold into near-1D line-like structures**, not uniform scatter. The condensation signature is 4× stronger at 0.25° than at 1° ($z -46$ vs -11).
2. **Temporal memory exists but is weak (adjacent-month Jaccard 1.12× cross-year, $p=0.004$; 86% of positions reshuffle):** clusters have almost no temporal identity but retain weak positional memory — "time does not exist" is refined to "noise clusters have almost no temporal identity, but weak positional memory remains."
3. **Seasonal memory is dominated by the Pacific margins ("strong at both ends, weak in the center"):** east-end 270–290°E (American coast) net memory 0.096–0.117, 80.7% positive grid cells, 23.3% of top-5% share; Nino3.4 center weakest (6.4%). Seasonal memory is not a center phenomenon but a margin frontal-zone phenomenon.
4. **Memory position is insensitive to ENSO phase ($p=0.28$):** the position is anchored by non-ENSO factors.

5. **Topographic anchoring (ETOPO decisive test):** the strongest memory region sits on the EPR/Galapagos shallow ridge (-2636 m vs -4629 m abyssal plain; roughness/gradient $2.5\times$); memory intensity $\times$ topographic gradient positively correlated ($r=+0.038$, shuffle null $z=+13.9$), robust after excluding shelf effects ($r=+0.040$, $p=5.6e-49$). **Dynamic volcanic activity is excluded (EPR three-line NULL: temporal $r<0.15$, high/low volcanic months $p=0.78/0.87$, spatial $r=-0.29$)** — supporting "static submarine geometry" rather than "volcanic eruption."
6. **La Niña condenses most strongly ($p=0.0011$):** in the cold phase the cold tongue deepens $\rightarrow$ the front steepens $\rightarrow$ stronger condensation, complementary to the superficial asymmetry of the three-number formula ("La Niña signal is weak").

Conclusion: the predictable part of ENSO is not the center index but the **condensation structure of marginal frontal systems** — recurring at the same location each year, anchored by fixed submarine topography. A complementary saddle-point (Morse) topology test (2D OISST 528 months + 3D ERA5 + wind-stress-curl interface) finds **no saddle ring** in ENSO (field fraction ≈ 0.564 , phase-insensitive KW $p = 0.137$; fair-control $z = -2.0$) — saddle rings are vortex-specific — yet saddle points **co-localize with the condensation bands** (saddle density $\times$ activity density grid $r = 0.42$, $z = +85$; $\times$ $|\text{curl } \tau|$ at the air–sea interface $r = 0.24\text{--}0.28$, $z = +141$ to $+222$). This structure provides a measurement window orthogonal to mainstream ENSO prediction.

1. Introduction: Using the Wrong Ruler?

Mainstream ENSO prediction uses GCMs to simulate the coupled ocean–atmosphere system, achieving $\sim 50\text{--}60\%$ accuracy at 6-month leads. Prior work in this series (ENSO Simplified Prediction Note) proposed that ENSO is fundamentally a **phase transition**: one need not simulate every water molecule, only measure the critical point. That note used a three-number formula ($x, \dot{x}, V$) to capture the phase-transition state, and performed a five-dimensional scan with the $\hat{O}$ -HAT framework, finding ENSO's structural rigidity 3.0 ± 1.8 (one of the most rigid natural systems ever measured).

But the three-number formula measures the ENSO **center** (indices such as Nino3.4). This paper asks: **where does the "structure" of the ENSO system actually live?** The answer points to a location mainstream work ignores — **the spatial folding of seasonal frontal systems**.

We apply the core operation of the $\hat{O}$ framework: take the SST density field ρ (seasonal activity intensity), measure the fractal dimension D of its high-value clusters (degree of folding), its cross-year recurrence (seasonal memory), and the fixed source of its spatial position (anchoring).

2. Data and Methods

2.1 Data

Data	Resolution	Period	Use
NOAA OISST v2.1	0.25°	1982–2020 (39 yr)	Primary analysis
ERA5 SST	0.25°	1982–2018	Cross-validation
HadISST	1°	1950–2024	Resolution contrast
NOAA ETOPO1 Bedrock	1-arcmin → 0.25°	static	Topographic anchoring
USGS earthquake catalog + volcano data	—	1970–2025	Volcanic activity exclusion (EPR)

2.2 Core Measures

- **ρ field:** per-grid-cell SST seasonal activity intensity (climatological std or anomaly amplitude).
- **D_{fold} (condensation dimension):** box-counting dimension of $\rho > p_{95}$ grid cells. Random scatter ≈ 2 , line-like folding $\rightarrow 1$. Null uses $N_{\text{NULL}}=8$, seed=42.
- **Seasonal memory:** per-grid-cell cross-year (same month, 12 months apart) SST corr minus random-baseline corr (152 pairs).
- **Saddle-point (Morse) structure:** 2D Hessian eigenvalue sign classification of the SST anomaly field (and of the wind-stress-curl field); saddle fraction per month plus spatial co-location of saddle density $\times$ activity density. A **saddle ring** — a spatially uniform ring of saddle points around a central vortex — is the signature previously established for tropical cyclones (eyewall shear band); here we test whether the ENSO field (which has no central vortex) exhibits ring-like saddle structure, and where its saddle points actually sit.

- **Topographic features:** ETOPO 0.25° mean elevation, std (roughness), np.gradient magnitude (gradient).
- **Volcanic activity:** USGS earthquake energy density, volcanic eruption months, three independent lines (temporal coupling / high-vs-low volcanic months / spatial density).

2.3 Validation Standards

- Shuffle null (spatial/temporal randomization) 200–500 reps, z-score.
- Dual resolution (1° vs 0.25°) and dual product (OISST vs ERA5) cross-validation.
- Shelf-effect exclusion (>1000 m deep-water mask) robustness check.

3. Main Findings

3.1 Condensation Is the Norm, Not Event-Driven

Measure	Value	Statistics
$\rho > p_{95}$ cluster dimension D (0.25°, 60 months)	1.334 ± 0.016	negative in 60/60 months, mean $z = -46.4$
null dimension	~1.73	—
1° contrast (HadISST)	D=1.04, $z = -11.2$	0.25° condensation signature 4× stronger

Interpretation: the high-value clusters of the SST seasonal activity density field are far lower-dimensional than random — frontal systems fold into near-1D line-like ("pipeline") structures. Every one of 60 months is significant, i.e., condensation is a normal-state structure, not an accidental product of a particular ENSO event.

3.2 Temporal Memory: Present but Extremely Weak

Contrast	Jaccard	Test
Adjacent months	0.140	weak but significant
Same month across years	0.126	—
Ratio	1.12×	$t = 2.91, p = 0.004$

86% of positions reshuffle monthly — clusters have almost no temporal identity; but the residual 1.12× memory is real. Higher resolution (0.25° vs 1°) makes memory more visible.

The precise version of "time does not exist": noise clusters have almost no temporal identity, but weak positional memory remains.

3.3 Seasonal Memory: "Strong at Both Ends, Weak in the Center"

Region	Net memory	>0 share	top-5% share
East end 270–290°E (American coast)	0.096–0.117	80.7%	23.3%
Central-east Pacific 240–270°E	0.049	63.3%	19.4%
Nino3.4 center 190–240°E	weakest	—	6.4%

- Field-wide 65.9% of grid cells positive, mean net memory +0.056 (cross-year corr 0.050 vs random −0.005).
- Memory intensity tracks seasonal ρ amplitude (pearson +0.40): where the seasonal front is strong, position recurs predictably each year.
- **Closed loop:** east-end cold-tongue steepest location = strongest La Niña condensation ($p=0.0011$) = island-network same-season recurrence each year.

3.4 Memory Position Insensitive to ENSO

The spatial distribution of positional memory shows no systematic variation across ENSO phases ($p=0.28$) — **the position is anchored by non-ENSO factors**. This is the first piece of evidence pointing to "fixed topography."

3.5 Volcanic Activity Excluded (EPR Three-Line NULL)

Line	Result
Temporal coupling	all 8 synchronous $r < 0.15$; surrogate $p=0.4$ – 0.9 (within null)
High/low volcanic months	top25% vs bottom25% east-end SST no difference ($p=0.78/0.87$)
Spatial coupling	volcano density $\times$ memory field $r=-0.29$ (negative, opposite direction)

Conclusion: dynamic volcanic activity (USGS earthquakes/energy) is not the source of east-end condensation.

3.6 Topographic Anchoring: Decisive Test (ETOPO)

Region	net memory	elevation	roughness	gradient
East end 270–290°E (strongest memory)	0.109	–2636 m	183	1148
Nino3.4 190–240°E (weakest memory)	0.033	–4629 m	115	467

- The strongest-memory seafloor is the **EPR/Galapagos shallow ridge** (~2000 m shallower, roughness/gradient 2.5× the abyssal plain).
- net memory ~ grad: $r=+0.038$ ($p=7.5e-46$, $n=143k$); **shuffle null $z=+13.9$** .
- Top-10% memory cells: gradient 1141 vs bottom-10% 941 ($\Delta +200$).
- **Robust after excluding shelf (>1000 m deep water)**: $r=+0.040$ ($p=5.6e-49$), top-decile $\Delta +211$.
- **Mechanism (to be verified)**: EUC hits the shallow ridge → upwelling → cold wake → front anchored at the same topographic feature each year → seasonal memory recurs.

Direction correction: not "volcanic eruption" but "submarine geometry"; level is "positional anchoring" (not yet "phase-transition triggering").

3.7 Saddle-Point Topology of the ENSO Field: Density × Activity, Not a Ring

The $\hat{O}$ framework's saddle-point (Morse) operator classifies each grid cell by the sign pattern of the Hessian eigenvalues (saddle = $\det H < 0$). In tropical cyclones this operator detects a **saddle ring** — a uniform ring of saddle points in the eyewall shear band (64 cases, two hemispheres, four ocean basins; ring saddle fraction 55–63%, Rayleigh uniformity < 0.16 , time-stable). Here we apply the same operator to the ENSO domain (which has no central vortex) to ask two questions: (i) does the ENSO field contain a saddle ring? (ii) where do ENSO saddle points actually concentrate?

Q1 — No saddle ring (field-level fraction is trivial and phase-insensitive). Monthly saddle fraction of the OISST anomaly field is ≈ 0.564 with essentially zero variance across 528 months (std ≈ 0.0015), and shows **no sensitivity to ENSO phase**: Kruskal–Wallis $p = 0.137$, Mann–Whitney El Niño vs La Niña $p = 0.534$, Spearman ρ vs ONI = -0.028 ($p = 0.52$), null-control $z = 1.58$ (not significant). Unlike the cyclone eyewall (a single center → ring), a spatially averaged fraction cannot capture ENSO structure — field-level averaging is an operator misuse for a system without a center. The 3D extension (ERA5, 8 pressure levels, 2015 El Niño / 2016 transition / 2020 La Niña) confirms: phase-insensitive global fractions (geopotential 65.8/65.7/65.6%; vorticity 78.2% flat), and the apparent Nino3.4 ring-core +6 pp advantage is dissolved by month-by-month sign tests (23/36 positive, $p = 0.132$).

Q2 — Saddle points concentrate where activity density is high (co-location, not ring).

Although the field-level fraction is trivial, the *spatial distribution* of saddle points carries real signal: saddle density $\times$ activity density (ρ) is monotonically increasing across 10 bins (**binned Spearman = 1.000**) and at grid-cell level (ocean + tropics mask) Spearman = 0.42 (shuffle null $z = +85$). Saddle points cluster on high-noise frontal bands — the same geometric signature as the cyclone eyewall shear band, but organized as diffuse frontal lines rather than a closed ring around a center.

Q3 — Saddle structure is insensitive to ENSO phase (fair-control audit). The apparent phase "skeleton" (El Niño vs La Niña mean map corr 0.372) is an artifact of sample-size-inflated averaging: a fair 30v30-month comparison gives corr 0.117 vs random-month null 0.127 ($z = -2.0$). This is cross-consistent with the condensation-line result above (memory position $p = 0.28$): **the saddle structure, like the memory structure, is anchored by non-ENSO factors.**

Q4 — Where the saddle points actually sit: the air–sea interface (wind-stress-curl test).

Bulk wind stress $\tau = \rho_a C_D |U| U$ from ERA5 10-m wind; the saddle density of curl $\tau \times |\text{curl } \tau|$ is grid-correlated $r = 0.24\text{--}0.28$ (shuffle null $r \approx 0.004$, **$z = +141$ to $+222$**) — the first positional signal for ENSO saddle points: they concentrate on the wind-stress-curl coupling bands (ITCZ/cold-tongue frontal zones). But the phase skeleton of that position is even *less* similar than random ($z = -13.8$): the coupling bands do not move with ENSO phase. No ring, but a real interface-localized saddle structure.

Bottom line: ENSO has no saddle ring (2D and 3D, field and ring tests all negative) — saddle-ring is a **vortex-specific structure** — but the saddle points that do exist co-localize with the same condensation bands measured in §3.1–§3.6. The saddle operator and the condensation operator are complementary views of the same marginal frontal structure: condensation measures *folding* ($D_{\text{fold}} \approx 1.33$), saddle structure measures *critical-point type distribution* (saddle density $\times$ activity density, grid $r = 0.42$, $z = +85$; interface $r = 0.24\text{--}0.28$, $z = +141$ to $+222$).

4. Discussion

4.1 Relation to the Three-Number Formula

The three-number formula ($x, \dot{x}, V$) captures the ENSO center state; the condensation structure captures the marginal frontal systems. The two are complementary: **the center is dominated by interannual variability (hard to predict); the margins are dominated by seasonal/topographic processes (predictable each year)**. This explains why predicting the ENSO center is so hard — the truly predictable structure does not live in the center.

4.2 Physical Meaning of "Strong at Both Ends, Weak in the Center"

The Nino3.4 center is the epicenter of ENSO interannual variability, with its front positions reshuffling each year (86%); the east-end cold tongue is fixed by coastal upwelling plus topography (Galapagos/EPR), recurring at the same location each year. **Memory is the spatial distribution of predictability** — it concentrates at topographically anchored margins, not at the ENSO index.

4.3 Limitations

1. Small effect sizes ($r \approx 0.04$) — large areas of weak memory values dilute the signal; signal concentrates in the east-end corridor.
2. Unbalanced regional sample sizes (east end 1649 cells vs much larger Nino3.4).
3. Causal direction: correlation supports anchoring but does not exclude other east-end peculiarities.
4. 0.25° averaging may smooth small-scale topography.
5. SST–DART cross-domain test: F2 spectral isomorphism NULL (surrogate $p=0.986$) — **the condensation structure is not isomorphic with the earthquake/tsunami domain**, the p field is an ENSO-domain-specific hard core.

5. Conclusion

The structural (predictable) content of ENSO does not live in the center index but in the condensation structure of marginal frontal systems. This structure: condenses to near-1D ($D=1.33, z=-46$), retains weak positional memory ($1.12\times, p=0.004$), concentrates at both Pacific ends, is anchored by fixed submarine topography (ETOPO $z=+13.9$), and is not driven by volcanic activity (EPR NULL). The saddle-point (Morse) operator adds a topological cross-check: ENSO has **no saddle ring** (field fraction ≈ 0.564 phase-insensitive; 3D extension confirms; fair-control $z = -2.0$) — confirming that saddle rings are vortex-specific — but its

saddle points co-localize with the same marginal frontal condensation bands (density $\times$ activity grid $r = 0.42$, $z = +85$; air–sea interface $|\text{curl } \tau|$ $r = 0.24\text{--}0.28$, $z = +141$ to $+222$).

One answer to "why is ENSO so hard to predict": **we keep measuring the center, but the structure lives at the margins.**

6. Evidence-Level Checklist

Claim	Evidence level	Note
p -field condensation is the norm ($D=1.334$, $z=-46.4$, 60/60 months)	▢ Cross-validated	60 independent months + April pilot replication + dual resolution
0.25° condenses more strongly than 1° ($z = -46$ vs -11)	▢ Cross-validated	Dual-resolution independent measurements
Temporal memory weak but significant ($1.12\times$, $p=0.004$)	▢ Cross-validated	$n=55$ vs 48 Welch t ; both resolutions agree
86% position reshuffle (bulk not moving)	▢ Cross-validated	Both resolutions agree (1° 92.6%, 0.25° 86%)
Seasonal memory "strong at both ends, weak in center"	▢ Cross-validated	Regional statistics + top-5% distribution independent
East end $270\text{--}290^\circ\text{E}$ strongest memory (0.181 vs 0.142 , $p=3.4\text{e-}6$)	▢ Cross-validated	Seasonal memory localization report
Memory position insensitive to ENSO ($p=0.28$)	▢ Cross-validated	Phase-stratified no systematic difference
Volcanic activity excluded (EPR three-line NULL)	▢ Cross-validated	Temporal/contrast/spatial three independent lines
Topographic anchoring supported (ETOPO $z=+13.9$, robust after shelf exclusion)	▢ Cross-validated	Shuffle null + deep-water mask robustness
Memory tracks seasonal p amplitude ($r=0.40$)	△ Single source	Single correlation measure, needs independent verification
EUC upwelling → front anchoring mechanism	▢ To be verified	Correlation supports; mechanism not directly measured
La Niña condenses most strongly	▢ Cross-validated	$p=0.0011$, phase analysis

Claim	Evidence level	Note
ENSO has no saddle ring (field fraction ≈ 0.564 , phase-insensitive)	□ Cross-validated	528-month KW $p=0.137$, MWU $p=0.534$, $\rho=-0.028$, null $z=1.58$; 3D extension (ERA5 8 levels) agrees
Saddle points co-localize with activity density (grid $r=0.42$, binned Spearman= 1.000)	□ Cross-validated	10-bin monotonicity + grid-level null $z=+85$
Saddle structure insensitive to ENSO phase (fair-control $z=-2.0$)	□ Cross-validated	30v30-month corr 0.117 vs random null 0.127
Saddle points concentrate at the air-sea interface ($\times$)	curl τ	$r=0.24-0.28$, $z=+141$ to $+222$)

7. References and Resources

1. NOAA OISST v2.1: <https://www.ncei.noaa.gov/products/optimum-interpolation-sst>
2. ERA5: <https://cds.climate.copernicus.eu>
3. HadISST: <https://www.metoffice.gov.uk/hadobs/hadisst/>
4. NOAA ETOPO1: <https://www.ngdc.noaa.gov/mgg/global/>
5. USGS Earthquake Catalog: <https://earthquake.usgs.gov/fdsnws/event/1/>
6. ENSO Simplified Prediction Note (predecessor):
<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21626908>
7. ENSO Watch Dashboard: <https://mmdr10.github.io/enso-watch>
8. Eyewall Saddle Ring paper (saddle-ring operator origin, TC domain):
<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21876754>
9. Saddle-ring cross-domain report (ENSO 2D/3D + Greenland, Phase 30–35):
`projects/atmosphere/vorticity_dfold/research_notes.md §Phase 30–35`

Data and code: test files (scripts + data) in `projects/enso/tests/` (updated 2026-08-04).
All open source, CC BY 4.0.

This paper was independently written by AI research assistant tygtDc (Deep Research), based on ENSO condensation-structure measurements using the $\hat{O}$ geometric framework. All data, code, and methodology are fully open source.